

Title: Rahasya

VOL. 1 :- UNCOVER

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Chapter 1: The Flight

Puja, a nurse aged 23 who is working in an Indian army hospital, who is thrilled to be going to her best friend's wedding overseas, boards an international passenger plane. The aircraft is packed with a mix of people—businesspeople, families, students, and a few foreigners. She settles down, reading a book, unaware that her life will be altered forever.

Halfway through the flight, turbulence rocks the plane violently. The crew tries to reassure the passengers, but in an instant, a massive explosion blows up from the engine. Oxygen masks fall, panic spreads, and the plane dives into a state of pandemonium. Puja hardly feels the deafening crash before passing out.

Chapter 2: Stranded

Puja comes to consciousness on a beach, her head aching. The plane wreckage smolders all around her. Of the hundreds on board, she and eight others survived. Among them is a ten-year-old named Nitya who lost both her parents in the disaster.

The survivors:

1. Puja (23, Nurse): Firm-willed and empathetic, she instinctively assumes control, nursing the injured and maintaining the group's unity.
2. Ajay (29, Electronics Engineer): Strategic and able, he instantly becomes the problem solver of the group, repairing and reusing things.
3. Rahul (19, Student): Courageous but hasty, he fights fear and self-doubt but yearns to be shown useful.
4. Meera (51, Journalist): Perceptive and cynical, she keeps a record of their adventures and keeps asking questions of the island's secrets.
5. Vikram (47, Doctor): Logical and systematic, he dresses wounds and keeps a cool head in times of crisis.
6. Ravi (60, Ex-Army Officer): Experienced but physically impaired, he offers strategic advice and moral support.
7. Elena (32, Foreign Backpacker): Adventurous and pragmatic, she brings with her survival experience from her travels and assists in food foraging.
8. Nitya (10, Orphaned Girl): Scared but tough, she holds on to Puja as a mother figure.

Starvation claws at them. They divide up what little food they can scavenge—canned packets of snack foods, a couple of bottles of water. Panic creeps in as the harsh reality hits them. Vikram cautions against dehydration, and Elena proposes foraging. They sit guard turns through the night huddled near a faint fire, listening as ominous noises reverberate through the jungle.

Chapter 3: The Village of Secrets

After walking through thick jungle, the survivors come upon a secret village. Initially, relief sweeps over them—civilization finally! However, as they near, they notice something is amiss. Villagers, dressed in unusual, outdated attire, regard them with suspicious gazes. They use an unintelligible dialect, so dialogue is impossible. Villagers avoid eye contact, while others whisper among themselves, their faces inscrutable.

When Puja and the others signal for assistance, the villagers turn a deaf ear. Even as they beg passionately for water or refuge, the villagers stand around them with an otherworldly indifference—only a few of them gazing at them with unnerving fascination. One of the villagers, an elderly woman with piercing eyes, mutters something to a young man before vanishing into a hut. The atmosphere is charged. Something is off.

That evening, the group camps on the village borders. While sleeping, Puja awakens to noises. She sees dark silhouettes observing them along the tree line. Horror seizes her, but before she can act, the silhouettes disappear.

Chapter 4: The Temple of Shadows

Hoping to know what happens to the villagers, Puja and some survivors infiltrate the village. They take a thin trail to the rear of the village, where Ajay observes strange symbols etched into trees. Meera, intrigued by the symbols, demands they trace them further into the jungle. After walking for hours through dense undergrowth, they see a moss-covered stone monument partly concealed under overgrown vines. Initially, they confuse it as ruins, but after they brush away the foliage, they find an entrance that goes underground—a temple, forgotten and old.

Within, the air is heavy with dust and the smell of rot. Faint torchlight flickers on the walls of stone, showing them detailed carvings. Initially, the group thinks that they are the graphic depictions of grotesque monsters devouring hapless victims. But Meera recognizes something unusual soon enough—scenes of a large boat, animals in twos, a large flood, and a mountaintop. It's Noah's Ark. Noah's ark was said to have taken one of everything with him that includes an element of evil as well.

As they move further into the temple, additional murals depict a lost legend—that this very island was the resting place of the Ark. The vessel, after rescuing life in the flood, arrived here. and then inexplicably disappeared. A ghost remained behind to watch over the holy ground, never permitting man or machine to enter or leave again. Bots get lost in storms. Planes crash from the heavens. The ghost—bitter, old—veils the island in delusions and storms, forestalling any rescue.

In the center of the room, they discover a pedestal upon which rests an ancient device, rusted gears. It appears as a puzzle—a sequence of turnable rings, each bearing mysterious symbols.

A mural on the last wall depicts an ominous prophecy: a red burst of light in the sky over the summit, and the ghost of the Ark stirring again.

They hear a snapping of twigs and startle—villagers have tracked them down. They run frantically to get away, just reaching their camp before the morning.

Chapter 5: The Descent into Madness

The group starts to disintegrate after Vikram vanishes. They have next to no food left, there is little in the woods, and the ever-present feeling of being spied upon chisels away at their minds. Paranoia creeps in like a dense fog. Ravi encourages the others to remain calm and together, but Rahul becomes more and more agitated, berating himself for allowing Vikram to go alone. Meera, with her journalist's instincts, is adamant that they must get concrete evidence of the island's sinister secrets—something to demonstrate that they are not dreaming.

And then a glimmer of hope. One morning, Puja sees a helicopter hovering over the beach close to their crash site. The family dashes outside, waving wildly and building a fire. For a moment of desperate-held breath, the helicopter stalls, appearing as though it has spotted them. But then, without warning, it careens mid-air—twirling grotesquely—and disappears behind the mountains that lie beyond the village.

Deciding to head along the only credible indication of rescue they've received, Puja goes with Ajay, Elena, and Ravi towards the plume of smoke rising on the opposite side of the island. The forest becomes denser the further they travel, vines that twist themselves around their calves like snakes. Bizarre symbols reappear on the trees, and the further they venture, the more warped time and sound become. Ravi, banking on his military experience, keeps them down-to-earth, leading the team like a field officer across enemy lines.

At the same time, Meera, Rahul, and Nitya, who had insisted on locating Vikram, quietly back to the village. Meera is in need of evidence of what they witnessed in the temple. Rahul, with still with a guilty heart, accompanies her with hesitant bravery. Nitya remains hidden at the edge of the jungle at Meera's command, holding a small idol she discovered near the temple's altar.

Within the village, they tread warily. The atmosphere is dense, stagnant, as though time has been suspended. Meera photographs ancient shrines, ritual symbols, and bizarre, mask-like totems. In the village center, they discover what they dreaded most: a stone altar, blackened with dried blood. Next to it lies Vikram's torn, blood-stained shirt. Meera's knees yield, and Rahul fists his hands in silent fury.

Before they are able to escape, masked villagers step out of the darkness—silent, phantom figures, gliding in almost-perfect unison. Rahul ushers Meera behind him and takes up a crude knife, but they are soon overpowered. As the villagers close in around them, Meera meets Nitya's gaze, still concealed in the bushes. The child blinks back, frozen with terror.

Just as villagers are about to drag Meera and Rahul away, Nitya spins around and makes a dash for the jungle. She moves at top speed, the trees engulfing her small body. With memory and instinct as her guides, she manages to follow the group's path somehow.

When Puja's group climb a ridge towards the site of the helicopter crash, they can hear despairing footsteps thudding through the scrub. In amazement, Nitya bursts through the thicket—followed close behind by Meera and Rahul, battered, bruised, but alive. The villagers, inexplicably, had released them.

Together again, the group huddles. Meera, shaken and unwavering, extracts her camera from her satchel. The photos she took—ritual artifacts, the altar, Vikram's remains—are incriminating. Ajay studies them in silence. They are no longer mere survivors. They must uncover the truth.

With fresh urgency, the survivors continue on to the site of the helicopter crash. The jungle clears to a clearing that's packed with mangled wreckage—not one helicopter, but parts of planes, boats, and even rusted metal from another time. It's a graveyard of lost hope, and it proves the gruesome reality: the island doesn't simply trap its victims—it invites them in, and it never releases them.

Chapter 6: The Last Signal

The wreckage field engulfs the team. It sprawls across the clearing like a scar—a baleful mosaic of smashed helicopters, rusty plane debris, broken wings, and shattered hulls. There are boats, aircraft, even pieces of what appeared to be a military drone all here, consumed by vines and moss. The island does not just ensnare its victims—it hoards them.

Among the wreckage, Ajay finds an old military radio in a smashed chopper cockpit. It's dusty but in one piece. "If we can find a power source, we might still have a chance," he says, studying the equipment. Meera and Elena search nearby wrecks and come back with a cracked emergency battery. Ajay plugs it in with trembling hands.

The radio crackles.

Static at first—then a voice. ". This is ATS Chennai. identify yourself.

Ajay answers, his voice shaking: "We are eight survivors of Flight I-472. on an uninhabited island. Coordinates unknown. Please send rescue at once."

Quiet. Then:

"Message received. Affirmed. Teams are being dispatched. Maintain position."

The survivors collapse. Puja hugs Nitya. Ravi dabs at his eyes with shaking fingers. Rahul laughs nervously. Meera holds her camera to her chest.

But they realize this is just the start of it. The sun starts to set, sending long, bony shadows over the wreckage. The jungle grows dark. The wind changes. The radio voice might have offered them hope—but survival until dawn was not an absolute."

They soon realize they have to ready themselves to survive one last night. The Navy could arrive in the morning, but until then, they were on their own. Ravi proposes climbing to the top ridge on the island—the spot shown in the temple mural—as their beacon point.

As they prepare to leave, the group spreads out across the plane graveyard. Survivor after survivor scavenges for anything they can use. Rahul discovers a jagged, sharp metal pipe. Elena scrounges wiring and scrap cloth to construct simple traps. Ajay uses paneling to turn into shields. Meera and Puja gather handheld containers of fuel and blunt instruments. In all, they craft simple weapons and armor, armor-plating backpacks and creating spears out of landing gear struts.

By the time darkness descends, they are tired—but prepared. Or at least as prepared as anyone might have been for whatever lay hidden in the darkness.

They climb back to the upper ridge indicated in the temple paintings—the site of the flare. Ravi coordinates the defense of their position, stacking rubbish and improvised barricades across

potential routes. Elena fuels Molotovs from looted fuel. Ajay sets up the flare gun and loads the single valuable flare. They get only one opportunity to be spotted.

As darkness falls, the jungle starts to stir. Whispering. Clicking. Chanting in a lost language. Eyes gaze out through the night.

They stand firm. Ravi refuses to limp. Puja grasps Nitya firmly. Meera writes on, even when her hands tremble.

In the midst of the chaos, Ajay looks up and sees lights shining on the horizon—ships coming in through the fog. His eyes widen in amazement. "The ships!" he shouts. "Puja—fire the flare, now!"

She ascends to the top of the ridge and shoots. A red flare shoots into the air, flaming like a comet. Next, spotlights burst through the clouds.

The villagers lament. Shrieks resound. Something titanic stirs in the woods—something older than the island itself. But before it comes to them, the gunfire of the Navy thunders from on high, pushing back the darkness.

The survivors are taken aboard the helicopters one by one. When Puja boards along with Nitya, she looks back. The village elder is standing by herself at the edge of the ridge, her eyes shimmering softly, her smile conscious.

Then—she disappears.

The helicopters take off, and the island disappears under veils of mist and storm.

Epilogue: The Island Never Lets Go

When the survivors reach back in India, a media frenzy erupts. Questions abound. Journalists grill the military for explanations. In a television interview, the military general nonchalantly brushes off the island's existence. "There is no island," he declares. "The survivors were rescued drifting on a wrecked lifeboat at sea—safe but disoriented."

The survivors, with Puja and Meera at the front, call for an investigation. They present Meera's camera, which is full of pictures of the village, the temple, the wrecks, and the rituals. Military intelligence deploys a scouting mission to confirm their tale.

What comes back is mystifying. Satellite photographs show just a tiny rocky outcropping in the middle of the sea—barely room for a single person to stand. No jungle, no village, no temple exists. It's as though the island had contracted, or just disappeared.

Worse, when the survivors talk of the battle, the killing of Vikram, Rahul, and soldiers who fought with them, they are denied. No records. No official recognition. As if their memories were erased from history.

Puja finds it hard to get on. Official reports say the island was uninhabited. She gets an anonymous package one day—inside, a small carved idol.

A whisper rings in her head: "The island never lets go."